

Operation Smiles

OneWord Coloring Book

English 9 Service-Learning Lesson Plan

English 9 | Virginia 2017 SOL Standards

Each student writes a 3–5 sentence story or short poem for one word, designs a coloring page in Canva or Google Drawings, and leaves space for a child recovering from surgery to finish the story and draw.

Course:	English 9
Duration:	2–3 class periods (90–100 minutes total)
Standards:	Virginia Writing 9.6a/b/c; Language 9.7; Reading 9.5
Technology:	Canva or Google Drawings · Google Classroom
Deliverable:	One illustrated coloring book page per student — assembled into one book per smile bag
Connection:	Each page pairs with the matching Env. Science student's OneWord 3D bookmark

Lesson Overview

The mission: Operation Smiles provides free cleft lip and palate surgeries for children in under-resourced countries. The Env. Science students at Kellam made a 3D printed bookmark with one word on it — a word that carries both a science meaning and a message of encouragement. Your students make the book those children will read and color while they heal. Each page pairs with one bookmark word. The child who receives a BLOOM bookmark gets the BLOOM page in their book.

The writing purpose: Students are writing for the most real audience possible — a child who has just had surgery and is beginning to heal. Every word choice matters. Every blank space they leave is an invitation for that child to finish the story themselves.

Learning Objectives

- Write an original short story or poem for a specific real audience — a young child in recovery — using age-appropriate language, imagery, and voice
- Use a single word as the generative center of a short story with a clear beginning, middle, and invitation to continue
- Create visual line art that supports the written narrative and functions as a coloring page
- Demonstrate understanding of writing for purpose and audience (Virginia SOL 9.6a/b)
- Self-edit for clarity, word choice, and tone appropriate to a young reader (Virginia SOL 9.7)

Virginia SOL Alignment

Standard	Connection to This Lesson
9.6a	Writing for a specific audience and purpose — students write for a real child with a specific emotional and developmental context
9.6a/b	Narrative and poetic writing — students craft a short original story OR poem with a clear arc and an open invitation for the reader to continue
9.6c	Word choice and voice — the story must use the OneWord meaningfully and speak with warmth and clarity to a young reader
9.7	Self- and peer-editing — students apply editing criteria for tone, word choice, sentence length, and age-appropriate language
9.5	Reading and responding to narrative texts — students study mentor texts of children's stories to understand how the form works before writing

Cross-curricular connection:

This lesson runs in parallel with the Operation Smiles OneWord Bookmark unit in Core Environmental Science.

Each Env. Science student designs and 3D prints a bookmark featuring one of 25 environmental science words.

Each English 9 student creates the matching coloring book page for that same word.

The finished smile bag contains: the 3D bookmark + the assembled coloring book — one complete gift made by two Kellam students.

Coloring Book Page Structure

Every page follows the same four-zone layout. Students use a Canva template or Google Drawings to build their page.

Zone	Section	What Goes Here
1	The Word	The OneWord printed large and bold at the top of the page — the title of the story. Students style this in their chosen font in Canva.
2	The Story or Poem	3–5 sentences of original narrative OR a short poem (4–8 lines, free verse or simple rhyme scheme). Simple language, warmth, and purpose. The word appears naturally somewhere in the writing.
3	Color / Draw Here	Student-designed line art illustration — black outlines only, no fill — for the child to color in. Connects visually to the story. Includes a small prompt: 'Color this picture.'
4	Finish the Story	A 1–2 sentence story starter the student writes, followed by lined blank space and the prompt: 'What happens next? You decide.' The child completes the story in their own words.

Page dimensions and print specs:

Page size: US Letter (8.5 × 11 inches), portrait orientation.

Color scheme: Black outlines only for the coloring section — no filled color in the illustration zone.

Font for the Word: Large, bold, decorative — at least 60pt. Canva has excellent display fonts for this.

Font for the story text: Clean, readable — at least 14pt. Avoid decorative fonts for the body text.

Print: Black and white is fine. The word at the top can be printed in color if desired.

Example Page — BLOOM (Story version)

BLOOM

After the long winter, something small and brave pushes through the cold ground. It does not wait to be told it is safe. It just blooms — because that is what it was made to do. You are like that too. You are already pushing through. You are already beginning to bloom.

[Coloring illustration — flower emerging from soil, line art only]

Color this picture. 🎨

One day, the flower opened its petals for the very first time and saw...

What happens next? You decide. ✏️

Word Assignment — 25 Words for 25 Pages

Assign one word per student. With a class of 25 or more, each word gets one page. With smaller classes, some words may have two students assigned — use the version you prefer, or combine them into one page.

Coordination with Env. Science teacher:

Share the word assignment list with the Env. Science teacher so the bookmark and the coloring book page always match. The smile bag assembler (you or a coordinator) matches the bookmark to page before stapling.

#	Word	Student	#	Word	Student
1	RENEW		14	CYCLE	
2	THRIVE		15	EMERGE	
3	BREATHE		16	ANCHOR	
4	BLOOM		17	ABSORB	
5	RESTORE		18	FILTER	
6	SUSTAIN		19	PERSIST	
7	RISE		20	CONNECT	
8	GROW		21	TRANSFORM	
9	FLOW		22	MIGRATE	
10	SHINE		23	ROOT	
11	HEAL		24	CLEAR	
12	BALANCE		25	RETURN	
13	ADAPT				

Day-by-Day Lesson Plan

DAY

1

Context, Mentor Texts & Word Assignment

⌚
45–50
min

Teacher goal for Day 1:

Students leave knowing their word, understanding the mission, and having read at least two mentor texts. They should feel the emotional weight of writing for a real child before they write a single word.

Opening — Operation Smiles Context (10 min)

- Show 2–3 photographs of Operation Smiles surgeries and recovery — children before and after, the smile bag being handed over. Let the images carry the emotional context without over-explaining.
- Ask: "What would you want to hold in your hands on the first day after surgery?" Take 3–4 responses. Hold silence after each one.
- Explain the bookmark pairing: the Env. Science students made a 3D printed bookmark with one word on it. Your students make the book that goes with it. Every child gets a bookmark and a book made specifically for their word.

Mentor Text Study (20 min)

- Share 2 short children's picture book excerpts — one that uses a single strong word as its emotional center (e.g. *The Invisible String*, *Brave*), one that leaves an open ending for the reader.
- Ask students: How does the author write for a young reader? What do you notice about sentence length? Word choice? What does the author leave unsaid?
- Chart responses — these become the class criteria for their own writing.

Word Assignment & Discovery (15 min)

- Assign each student their word. Give them 5 minutes to free-write: What does this word make you picture? What feeling does it carry? Don't think about science — just the word.
- Share out briefly. Notice how the same word means different things to different people — that's the point.
- Introducing the Env. Science connection: this word also lives in a science classroom. The student who made your bookmark had to research what BLOOM means for an ecosystem, write encouragement, and connect both meanings. You're writing for the same child. Introduce the choice: students may write a short story (3–5 sentences) or a short poem (4–8 lines, free verse or simple rhyme). Both must use the word naturally and speak directly to the child.

DAY

2

Write, Illustrate & Design

⌚
45–50
min

Teacher goal for Day 2:

Students produce a complete draft of their story and a rough sketch of their illustration. By the end of class they should have all four zones filled in draft form before moving to Canva or Google Drawings.

Writing Mini-Lesson — Writing for a Young Reader (10 min)

- Model both forms briefly: write a 3-sentence story AND a 4-line poem using the same word. Think aloud for each: for the story — scene, action, turn toward the child. For the poem — image, feeling, invitation. Students choose which form fits their word and their instinct.
- Show the four sections on the projected template. Explain: The Word and Connect are the story. Analyze what the child colors. Respond is what the child finishes. Your job is to make them want to pick up a crayon AND a pencil.

Independent Writing (20 min)

- Students draft their story or poem in Google Docs or on paper. Circulate and conference briefly — push for specificity of image and directness of voice. The Gemini Writing Coach Gem is available now for students who want feedback on their draft.
- Key questions to ask while circulating: 'Does your word appear in the story? Does the child feel spoken to, or just told something? What's the one image you want them to color?'
- Students also draft their Respond story starter — the incomplete sentence the child will finish.

Illustration Sketch & Canva/Google Drawings Setup (15 min)

- Students sketch their coloring illustration on paper first — one clear scene, simple outlines, no shading or fill. Remind them: the child colors this, so leave it open.
- Open Canva (canva.com) or Google Drawings. Students begin building their page using the four-zone layout. The teacher shares a Canva template link or Google Drawings starter file.
- Zones 1 and 2 (word title + story text) can be completed digitally today. Analyze (illustration) may carry into Day 3 for students who need more time.

Canva setup tip:

Create one Canva template with the four zones pre-laid out (text boxes in position, illustration zone outlined) and share it via a class link. Students duplicate the template and work in their own copy. This saves significant setup time and keeps all pages consistently sized.

Gemini Writing Coach Gem:

Share the Writing Coach Gem link alongside the Canva template. Students open it when they want feedback on their draft — it responds to what they actually wrote, asks what they want the child to feel, and pushes for stronger images without writing for them. See the companion Gemini Gem Setup Guide for English 9.

Peer Edit — Audience Check (15 min)

- Students swap Google Doc drafts with a partner. Editing focus: Would a young child understand every word? Does the story feel warm and personal? Does Respond make you want to finish the sentence?
- Use the editing criteria charted on Day 1. Students leave written feedback, not just marks.

Revise & Finalize Canva Page (25 min)

- Students apply peer feedback, finalize their story text, and complete their illustration in Canva or Google Drawings.
- Checklist before submitting (display on board):
 - ✓ Word appears in Zones 1 and somewhere in the story
 - ✓ Story is 3–5 sentences and speaks directly to the child
 - ✓ Illustration is line art only — no filled color
 - ✓ Respond has a story starter and a 'What happens next?' prompt
 - ✓ Page is sized US Letter and ready to print

Submit & Export (5 min)

- Students download their Canva page as a PDF (File → Download → PDF Print) or export from Google Drawings as PDF.
- Submit to Google Classroom. The teacher prints all 25 pages, assembles in word order, and staples one copy per smile bag.

Assessment

Rubric — OneWord Coloring Book Page (100 points)

Criteria	Strong (A)	Developing (B/C)	Beginning (D/F)
Story or Poem (40 pts)	3–5 sentences or 4–8 lines; word appears naturally; voice is warm and speaks directly to the child; at least one vivid image; form is handled with intention	Writing is present but generic or does not address the child directly; word may be absent or forced; limited imagery or form feels accidental	Too short, copied from a model, or does not speak to the child; word missing
Illustration (30 pts)	Original line art that clearly connects to the story; outlines are clean and leave meaningful space to color; complexity appropriate for a child	Illustration is present but loosely connected to the story; may have filled areas or be too simple to engage a child with coloring	Illustration is missing, traced from another source, or not suitable as a coloring page
Respond — Story Continuation (20 pts)	Story starter is compelling and open-ended; prompt 'What happens next?' is clear; blank lines are provided and sufficient for a child to write	Starter is present but may be too leading (gives away the answer) or too vague to inspire a response	Respond is missing or just a blank space with no starter sentence
Craft & Editing (10 pts)	Age-appropriate vocabulary throughout; no errors that would confuse a child reader; Canva page is clean, legible, and print-ready	A few vocabulary or editing issues; page is mostly legible but may have formatting inconsistencies	Multiple errors; page is difficult to read or not formatted for printing

Book Production & Smile Bag Assembly

Printing

- Print all 25 student pages single-sided on white paper. Black and white is fine — the child will add the color.
- Optional: print The Word in color for a more inviting cover impression. All other sections print black and white.
- Print one copy per smile bag needed. If you have 30 bags, print 30 copies of each page.

Assembly

- Sort pages in word order (alphabetical works well: ABSORB, ADAPT, ANCHOR... or thematic groupings).
- Add a cover page — a simple title page: 'Stories for You — Made by Kellam High School Students, Virginia Beach, Virginia.' Include the Operation Smiles logo if available.
- Staple in the upper left corner, or have the pages saddle-stitched at a copy center if producing a large quantity.
- Place one assembled book per smile bag alongside the matching 3D bookmark.

The matching system:

Each smile bag should contain a bookmark AND the page that matches its word.

The simplest approach: when assembling bags, pull the bookmark first, read the word, then pull that page from the coloring book and place it loose on top before sealing.

The full book goes in every bag — the matching page is just placed on top as a 'your page' moment.

Cover Page Suggestion

Stories for You

A Coloring Book Made Just for You



Written and illustrated by students at
Kellam High School — Virginia Beach, Virginia

In partnership with Operation Smiles
Read it. Color it. Finish it. It's yours.